

CONSUMER FIRMS AHEAD

- Consumer firms have the highest number of women directors, followed by industrials and commodities
- In the financial services sector, women hold only 19% of total directorships, but it makes it to the Top 5 in terms of overall numbers

Industry	Total Directorships	Total Women Directorships
CONSUMER DISCRETIONARY	4,993	1,123
INDUSTRIALS	3,830	803
COMMODITIES	2,302	463
FINANCIAL SERVICES	1,935	370
FAST MOVING CONSUMER GOODS	1,333	297

SOURCE PRIMEINFOBASE.COM



“A start has to be made somewhere. If every job required prior experience, no one would ever get an opportunity”

Pranav Haldea
MD, PRIME DATABASE GROUP

116 |

LEGAL BOOST?

Considering the slow progress on diversity, should the legal mandate for women directors be increased from one to two? This proposal has gained traction, with advocates arguing that having at least two women on boards could counter tokenism and ensure more diverse perspectives are considered. “There is a compelling argument to be made for increasing the legal mandate for women directors from one to two,” says Kumar. That would not only further the objective of gender diversity but would also mitigate the risks associated with tokenism, where the presence of a single woman on the board may be seen as merely symbolic, he adds.

The inclusion of more women directors could accelerate cultural shifts within corporate India, fostering a more inclusive governance environment. Besides, it may even improve the chances of women being selected as key management personnel. One thing that is consistent across regions in the Deloitte report is that the representation of women on boards is much better in organisations where women have leadership roles.

Such a cultural shift is essential for aligning business practices with evolving societal expectations, where inclusivity is no longer optional but necessary. Research supports this, showing that companies with gender-diverse boards tend to outperform their peers in terms of financial performance, risk management, and innovation. “This diversity of thought translates into stronger policies, more inclusive workplace cul-

tures, and better risk management, ultimately contributing to long-term growth and stability,” Lexlevel’s Sharma emphasises.

Women often bring different perspectives, experiences, and problem-solving approaches that enable companies to better understand and cater to a diverse customer base. This diversity of thought is crucial in today’s complex business environment, where companies face evolving challenges and rapidly changing market dynamics. The inclusion of women on boards leads to more comprehensive decision-making processes that consider various stakeholder interests, thereby enhancing overall corporate governance standards.

The push for gender diversity in boardrooms is more than just a compliance issue. It represents a broader movement toward more inclusive and effective governance. While regulatory mandates have begun the process, achieving true gender parity requires a concerted effort to address cultural mindsets, structural barriers, and unconscious biases that continue to hinder women’s advancement in corporate India. By expanding opportunities, companies can unlock the full potential of gender diversity, benefitting not only their governance but also their bottom line. As India continues its journey toward a more inclusive corporate landscape, the board game is changing—slowly but surely—ushering in a new era of equitable leadership. **BT**

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